It's not just Hindi cinema that's obsessed with gods. Tamil and Telugu cinema, too, have a rich history of drawing inspiration from the Mahabharata and the Ramayana to create blockbusters like *Mayabazar* (1957), a mythological drama centred around Arjuna's son Abhimanyu and Balarama's daughter Sasirekha. Both S.S. Rajamouli and Nag Ashwin cite it as one of their favourite films and effectively incorporate Hindu deities in their narratives—be it the Ram-inspired imagery in *RRR*'s now-iconic



"Today, certain films mobilise mythology to advance Hindutva ideology, privileging a homogenised, ethnonationalist majoritarian identity over India's plural, diverse cultural landscape"

Sanghita Sen, *Assistant professor, Northumbria University, Newcastle*

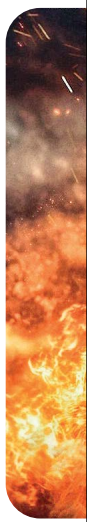
action sequence featuring Ram Charan to Amitabh Bachchan's Ashwathama and Prabhas's Karna in sci-fi epic *Kalki 2898 AD*. Telugu filmmaker Prasanth Verma, too, has announced a cinematic universe inspired by Indian mythology. After the superhero film *Hanu-Man* (2024), his next, *Mahakali*, arrives in cinemas in January, followed by *Jai Hanuman* with Rishab Shetty and Rana Daggubati.

The Bhakti Bandwagon

Making films about gods and epics may have become a new trend, but the risk of offending religious sentiments is an old one. "It's a double-edged sword," says Ashwin Kumar. "We have to stay true to the intent, the shastra, to the legend. Otherwise, it could backfire." Chaturvedi, too, stresses







1. *Varanasi*
Director
S.S. Rajamouli
Producers
K.L. Narayana & S.S. Karthikeya
Date of release
Apr. 7, 2027
Indian cinema's favourite maverick director is back with an action-adventure film. It has Varanasi facing an asteroid threat in a globe-trotting tale across periods, including a segment on Hinduism's supergods. Mahesh Babu plays two roles, including Ram.

2. *Mahavatar Parshuram*
Director
Ashwin Kumar
Producer: *Kleem Productions*
Expected release
2027
Narsimha surprised many after emerging as a major 2025 blockbuster. Kumar now looks to continue the good run with yet another animated fare on Vishnu avatar Parashuram.

3. *Mahavatar*
Director
Amar Kaushik
Producer
Maddock Films
Expected release
TBA
Vicky Kaushal gets into god mode for *Stree* director's super-sized retelling of, yes, again, Chiranjeevi Parashuram. The film marks Maddock Films' first foray into the mythological genre.